

**Park & Recreation Commission WA 26
Subcommittee Working Group**

Meeting Minutes

Date: July 12, 2022

Place: Zoom Webinar

Committee Members Attending: Clara Bachelor, Carla Benka, Lauren Bernard, Charlie Homer, Pam Lodish, Theresa Mooney, Nancy O'Connor, Stephen Reeder, Wendy Sheridan Ames

Co-Petitioners: Deborah Brown, Kimberly Richardson

Staff: Leigh Jackson, Jon Lewitus, Gerry Kelly, Laurie Ferrell

TOPIC	KEY POINTS/DISCUSSION
Welcome/Call meeting to order/Introductions	• Meeting commenced @ 1:01 PM • W. Sheridan Ames called the meeting to order • L. Jackson introduced Laurie Ferrell as the new administrator who will support the work of the Park and Recreation Commission, subcommittees, and working groups. • L. Ferrell announced though this is a public meeting, there will be no public comment. • Introductions of the WA 26 Committee members.
WA 26 Summary	• C. Benka - reviewed the WA 26 Chart which breaks up WA 26 into sections based on purpose, agent, and a schedule of work. See WA 26 Chart here. There is a comprehensive plan for Parks which is presented every 5 years with annual updates. This is the basis for capital improvement fund requests to upgrade and renovate our parks. The petitioners have in mind we do the same for recreational programming. Sections of the plan are as follows: 3.16.2 Park and Recreation Area Programs 3.16.3 Park and Recreation Affordability 3.16.4 Park and Recreation Funding 3.16.5 Open Space Design Review Panel 3.16.6 Women and Disadvantaged Business Enterprise 3.16.7 Promulgation of Regulations • W. Sheridan Ames suggested it would be helpful to create smaller working groups outside of this meeting that can work on achieving goals of these various sections.
Recreation Department Existing Strategy	• L. Jackson presented the Power Point – Existing Strategy and Barriers. See presentation here. • She presented the mission, focus, vision, and values of the Recreation Department including an equity and community engagement plans. She discussed: 1. Specific strategy/events serving all families more equitably – prior to WA 26 filing.

2. Specific strategy prior to the WA 26 filing: Recreation financial aid facts – a 5-year history of providing financial aid. In the fiscal year just ended, we gave 107 scholarships totaling \$55,000. For qualifications we use limit from HUD programs to determine eligibility. We also partner with the Park School summer program where they give 11 full-time spots to Steps to Success students.

Discussion:

S. Reeders asked (referring to the 3rd slide) if you plan for an enrollment of 10, and staff accordingly, what is the true cost if only 8 show up and the other 2 slots are given (no charge), what is the true cost? The variable cost of an addition participant.

G. Kelly response: The camp is a licensed program and we do have ratios we need to follow. We do sell out and have a waiting list.

L. Jackson added this is a subsidy and are not the actual costs. We do have a financial sustainability model that includes the fixed and variable cost which I am happy to share once we get into breakout groups.

S. Reeders also asked are if there are other schools within our boundaries that we could partner with?

L. Jackson response: Yes, we do have partnerships with a few schools but there are opportunities for more partnerships. The Windsor School allows us to access to their gyms for our recreation therapy program and in exchange they can utilize such our tennis courts at Amory in May.

W. Sheridan Ames added Dexter and Beaver Country Day also have robust summer camp programs. She asked L. Jackson to provide the MOA with Windsor.

C. Homer asked what Steps for Success is?

J. Lewitus response: It is one of our partnership programs where we take high school aged kids and set them up for success in job training and future things after high school. In addition, we take school-aged children from low-income house and provide opportunities such as summer camp and other programs.

C. Homer asked how to people get into Steps to Success?

J. Lewitus responded: It is a referral service. We do not know how they identify their students.

C. Benka said it originally started with upper grade kids in Brookline public housing. With additional funding, they have been able to start kids at younger ages. It is used for academic support during the school year. Also, there are intense efforts to find them summer internship jobs to expose them to a variety of professions that they may want to pursue post college.

J. Lewitus mentioned a counselor-in-training program for high school-aged students and the camp program for younger kids.

L. Bernard said Steps to Success now goes down to 3rd grade

kids. The program for grades 3-5 is called AHU. For grades 6 - 7 it is called Teen Advantage Program and then there is a high school group. Along with the academic programs, they really work hard to get students internships.

C. Homer asked do we have any sense of what the need is from Brookline Housing Authority? How many SDS kids would be eligible if spaces were not limited?

L. Jackson response: The best person to answer this question would be Juan Cantu or Michael Alperin – both have been asked to join this committee.

C. Benka asked if most of the financial aid for summer camp?

G. Kelly responded: 60 – 70%.

C. Benka also asked if the financial aid directed to kids vs. adults?

G. Kelly response: Both, but the majority was for youth.

C. Benka asked if there was any thought given to the Council on Aging as part of community outreach?

L. Jackson response: Not yet. Right now, our focus is low-income families. We do have a robust senior program that is meeting again post COVID.

W. Sheridan Ames questioned the cost issue of planning for 1 participant and 1 teacher for a program but 15 enroll. At some point you need to decide to run it or not.

G. Kelly added with our cost recovery model, we base it on a program being at full capacity and set fees accordingly. If there is an opportunity we can add 3 more students, we can offer these 3 slots for free.

W. Sheridan Ames suggested when people register for programs do we have a checkbox for people to donate to a person-in-need scholarship.

G. Kelly response: We used to but there was minimal response.

L. Jackson response: We can look into that.

T. Mooney asked do we have a sense of how many kids or families have applied and we say the money is not there?

L. Jackson added we have never turned anyone away.

N. O'Connor suggested we charge a bit more, so we are charging for 10, though the capacity is 8, allowing room for 2 free slots.

The Park School is wonderful and provides us with their summer camp program. The partnerships with other schools is for field use. Let's make sure that we are getting from them, as they are getting from us.

She added we should think beyond summer camp, such as sports programming, swimming, etc. including Viking Sports and Net Results that they are they on board offering free spots and scholarships? We need to include all residents in town, including

seniors, we should be servicing everyone.

C. Bachelor mentioned one must put 20% down prior to applying for a scholarship which may be cost prohibitive.

G. Kelly response: If they did put 20% down, we would give it back but generally we don't take the 20% and let them sign up. We will work with families who are unable to put down the 20%.

L. Jackson continued her presentation.

BREC FY 22-23 Community Engagement Plan

The focus is on low-income families. We held an event, collaborating with Brookline Public Housing and Viking Sports. We engaged our community and allowed their feedback as part of our design.

Community Engagement: Survey Result highlights:

20 participants took survey which revealed:

Many were not aware of our financial aid program, less than half, less than half rely on public transport, none had been to the Town Golf Course. The biggest barrier was cost, then location and transport.

Specific Strategy to Serving All Families More Equitably – May/June 2022

During the WA 26 Town Meeting, D. Brown and community partners asked L. Jackson if there was anything we could do to get more kids into Camp 2022?

Response: FY 22 Summer Camp Pilot was created.

Result: 22 children attended Summer Camp for free.

Community Collaboration: Special Summer Camp Pilot – Summer 2022 – successful outcomes.

1st meeting outcome - 10 spots can be utilized by same families or can be broken up to give 2 weeks time.

2nd meeting outcome - reports by Juan Cantu (STS), discussion groups, J. Lewitus, L. Jackson, D. Brown, D. McDonald. (See presentation link above).

Current Barriers for Giving More Subsidy/Financial Aid

We run a revolving fund which is self-sustaining, based on cash receipts, and needs to balance every year. Currently, financial aid is not a line-item in the budget. We need financial support for these efforts. Cash overages allow us to give subsidies/financial aid. The Financial Aid Policy needs to be updated to allow us to utilize the ARPA funds up to 100% of coverage for programs. We also have staffing challenges, and it is not the budget to hire additional staff in FY 23/24. Lack of space is another barrier. We do not have a community/rec center, so we used school space when

available. We don't have enough field space or gyms.

Current Ideas to Tackle the Barriers - highlights

Update the Financial Aid Policy with new criteria.

- Make the application process easier – work with the public schools' free lunch program.
- Start a campaign to get Financial Aid into the General Fund
- ARPA funds for 2 years – need process to access
- Hire a part-time admin for grant writing
- Consider raising fees once ARPA funds are exhausted
- Develop a comprehensive marketing plan that reaches families in need in collaboration with STS and other groups.
- Develop/adopt program strategy to better serve families in need.

Recreation Ideas: For Consideration

- Mobile recreation – take the programs to the people
- We have internal caps, but we can take more kids.
- Reserve 10% of total spots in certain programs for the ARPA funded pilot. Roughly 150+ spots.
- The next opportunity to implement this plan is our fall programs. We will continue to expand and evolve.

Recreation Ideas: For Consideration - Continued

Non-sports programs such as health and wellness, art, senior programs, to serve people of all ages.

J. Lewitus added we currently have waiting lists for all our programs. Our challenge is how do we allow everyone into our programs when they are fully booked?

L. Jackson added part of moving forward is utilizing the Robert T. Lynch golf course better. We are currently working on the First Tee Program for kids that want to learn to play golf. Other uses for the golf course are fundraisers, health and wellness classes, and other community events but more funding is needed.

She appreciates the support of the Commission, the town, and the community.

Discussion:

C. Homer asked L. Jackson to explain the relationship

between the ARPA funding and the 22 additional spots?

He also asked is the revolving fund the entire funding for the entire department and how profitable is the golf course?

L. Jackson response: We did not use the ARPA funds for the 22 people. Since our budget was in the black, we felt comfortable giving away more free seats. We have a call scheduled where we will discuss how and when the ARPA

	funds will become available. 70% of our budget comes from the revolving fund (\$4mil). The General Fund supports senior management salary. The golf course runs on an Enterprise fund (\$2mil) – money that comes into this fund, stays with the fund, per policy. W. Sheridan Ames stated no Commissioners were part of the discussions regarding funding the 22 slots. The ARPA funds are sitting in the Safety Net fund at the Brookline Community Foundation, but it has not been decided how those funds will be used though there is a timeline. How those funds are dispersed will be voted on by the Select Board but maybe this committee can help guide potential programs so recreation dept. staff as the experts can come up with terrific pilot plans like the one J. Lewitus presented. Additional uses for the ARPA funds, can come out of this committee. L. Jackson stated the Cost Recovery model has been rebranded as the Cost Sustainability model which she feels is more appropriate. We rely on cash overages to fund affordability at the lower end. We also rely on partnerships, such as Viking Sports and Net Results, where we have agreements that pay the Recreation Dept. to run their programs. That money gets put into the revolving fund. We also have funds that come from Beaver Country Day because they use some of our facilities. So, there are other ways to look at overall funding. S. Reeder wonders, as part of recreation, if we could build some specific health programs/education around the obesity epidemic. L. Jackson response: She would support that. During COVID we had to lay off our Health and Wellness rec leader though she is trying to bring that position back. N. O'Connor said let's make this happen as quickly as we can. Schedule events more than quarterly by collaborating with Michael Alperin, folks at BHA and other community groups. She suggested weekly events with a particular themes such as art, sports equipment, board games, etc. Or go to their locations monthly. C. Homer added childhood obesity and mental health are topics highly relevant for getting grants. N. O'Connor asked if Public Health could provide guidance? C. Homer responded perhaps and mentioned additional programs regarding diabetes prevention.	
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	L. Bernard asked, concerning the fact we do not have a recreation center; how much does that limit the possibility of expanding programs to the underserved populations? L. Jackson response: She does not feel this is associated with providing programming though it is a barrier yet there are ways to get around barriers. Yes, not having a center is a limiting factor and I do think we deserve a rec center. I do have a dream! N. O'Connor said it would be great to have a rec center but believes Jon and Gerry have the expertise to know what people want and can come up with creative ways to make it happen. We need to think outside the box. L. Jackson stated with new data, we will learn a lot. We can try the new things she presented and is interested in hearing more.	
Development of Working Groups	W. Sheridan Ames we should consider how complicated this is and how many directions we need to go. The Dream Big is to serve every family in town that has a need for recreation and make access to that recreation as easy as possible and affordable. To have free recreation for those in need with no barriers. Referring to the WA 26 Chart (see link above), she suggested to develop working groups coinciding with the sections on the chart and see who might be willing to work in these groups outside of the larger meetings. C. Benka said in terms of the health and wellness aspect, she mentioned various organizations which may have funding for these efforts. She cautioned that we have a report to deliver to town meeting by November and suggested preparing a timeline for at least presenting a progress report and outlining plans for the future. D. Brown stated we need to do at minimum what is in Article 26 as it was bare bones. We need to have solutions consistent with what was said at town meeting, and nothing less. W. Sheridan Ames said our goal is to have people work on real possible ideas and solutions under each of the categories. C. Homer supports the goals as presented. We need to quantify the need more clearly. We need to simplify and make the application process more welcoming. We should have a group work on how to make the criteria clear – SNAP or Medicaid, etc. We also need a group to address financing and issues of monitoring and reporting.	

	W. Sheridan Ames volunteered to take the first pass at getting the categories down that we have identified today and sort through the subcategories. Then the Rec. Dept. can work on getting them out for everyone to see who can work on what. D. Brown thinks that the Warrant Article can dictate the structure. She doesn't want to lose time recreating what we need to do. W. Sheridan Ames stated once we connect people to the working groups, people can work together on scheduling, L. Jackson responded those will not be public meetings. She would like to get the larger Committee meeting on the calendar. It was suggested the meetings occur every two weeks. W. Sheridan Ames will confer with L. Jackson about scheduling future meetings. N. O'Connor asked how do we make sure these efforts – funding, programming, etc. - continue for a long time to come? Through by-laws? This is a bucket we need to look at by people who know how government and municipalities work.	
Adjourn	• Meeting adjourned @ 3:00 PM	

Next Meeting: August 1, 2022

Location: Zoom Webinar

A true record

Attest: Laurie Ferrell

Date: July 12, 2022